asked them if they were aware of what was going on in Foz do Iguacu. From the looks that were exchanged around the table I realized that they had no idea what I was talking about. I described to them in detail the situation there and the potential risks involved. At the end of the meal, the director instructed his people to begin looking into the subject. And indeed, the CIA began to invest resources into it, including through cooperation with some of the intelligence and security services in South America. Unfortunately, we were unable to prevent the terrorist attacks on the embassy and community center in Buenos Aires, which, with the wisdom of hindsight, were written on the wall.

My first visits to Langley were in 1989, at the end of the Cold War, when the Soviet Union was at the top of the CIA's EEI. During each of these visits I had the opportunity to meet with both operations and research people. The meetings were informal, and when the subject of discussion was the Middle East they took the form of a dialogue, whereas when the subject was the Soviet bloc they were for the most part briefings for me. The researchers were real experts, each in his or her own field of expertise, yet curious to hear every word uttered by a visitor from the Middle East.

I will never forget the last briefing I received on the Soviet bloc, at a time when one could already sense the impending collapse of the Soviet Union. The researchers who briefed me bombarded me with data on the volume of Soviet agricultural production and coal and steel output over the previous year and their forecasts for the following year, and endless other statistics, all of which were seen as indicators of the strength of the Soviet Union. It was implied, though not explicitly stated, that the bottom line of this briefing was that in terms of its capabilities the Soviet Union still constituted a real threat to the United States.

I did not feel like a great expert on the Soviet Union in that setting, and I did not want to pester the researchers with questions, but I was reminded of a seminar I had taken at Harvard in 1985 about the methodology used to build the US defense budget. To an observer, the seminar seemed more like a math lesson than an in-depth discussion that took into account all nonquantifiable variables in assessing the enemy's power. And to those who might respond that a university seminar is no more than an academic exercise, I would point out that William Kaufmann, the professor who taught the seminar, was considered the guru of the Pentagon, with no defense